

Judicial Connections*

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Abstract

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1 Introduction

For justice to be blind, judges should be unbiased. However, we know that judge bias can happen in a variety of situations, mostly related to race, ethnicity, and gender of the litigants.¹ What we know less about is how judge and lawyer connections can cause judicial bias and what are the consequences for individuals and firms involved in the lawsuits.² The problem of preferential treatment in court is as old as the judiciary itself (North and Weingast), while it still remains a politically and economically relevant problem today.

When individuals and firms can impartially enforce contracts in courts, in theory this should lead to welfare-enhancing situations. In practice, judges and courts are often biased and partial in the enforcement of contracts, which could lead to a situation where individuals or firms increase their well-being at the expense of others (Djankov et al). [This leads to also looking at what are the downstream consequences for firms and individuals of bias in the enforcement of labor contracts resulting from lawyer-judge connections.] (probably not going this way. is there more lit about psychological/social contract effects of thinking that justice is not blind?)

In this paper, using random assignment of cases to judges (Kling, Waldfogel), we document that lawyers connected to judges are more successful than other lawyers and that they owe this success partly to their connections. We link data on the universe of Brazilian labor cases filed between 2014 and 2018 to administrative data on family relations to identify lawyers with family ties to judges. We consider two types of lawyer connections: (i) relatives of judges, and (ii) colleagues of relatives of judges.³

We find that relatives of judges receive 75% more cases than other lawyers in the same municipality with the same age and years of schooling receive. Controlling for the number of cases received, relatives of judges have cases with 21% higher average face value than those of comparable lawyers, and represent firms with 85% more employees. Similar results apply to colleagues of relatives. While these differences could be driven by unobserved differences in skills or motivations of connected lawyers, we exploit random assignment of cases to judges to document that these differences are at least partially due to their connections.

¹See alesina and ferrara; glaeser and sacerdote; Gazes ayal; abrams et al; shayo and zussman; cohen and yang; eren and mocan; arnold, dobie and yang; Starr 2015; rehavi and starr 2014. See harris and sen for a review including ideology.

²The general consequences stemming from political connections are of course a large, established literature beginning with Fisman (2001). For its effects in the judiciary see (Political connectedness and court outcomes: evidence from Chinese corporate lawsuits; The Effects of Political Connections and State Ownership on Corporate Litigation in China; Perverse Complementarity: Political Connections and the Use of Courts among Private Firms in China). However, the consequences of *judicial connections* have not yet been explored.

³Two lawyers are considered colleagues if they appear in at least five cases together.

We document clear signs of favoritism: Focusing on cases where the plaintiff is represented by a lawyer connected to an active judge in the court, we find that the value awarded the plaintiff increases by 30–40% if the case is randomly assigned the connected judge. The estimated effect is larger the stronger is the connection between the lawyer and the judge: The effect is larger for colleagues of close relatives than for colleagues of extended family and seems to increase with the number of joint cases between a lawyer and the judge’s relative.

A reason why outcomes favor the plaintiff when the case is assigned a judge connected to a plaintiff lawyer could be that lawyers are better at convincing judge’s they know. This mechanism cannot be the full explanation, however: We also document that judges favor connected plaintiff lawyers by scheduling the first hearing earlier, reducing case duration by 20%. Thus judges favor connected lawyers even before hearing their arguments.

Interestingly, while we find strong effects of being assigned a connected judge when the connected lawyer represents the plaintiff (worker), we find no effects when the connected lawyer represents the defendant (firm). An explanation for this asymmetry could lie in differences in contractual terms between plaintiff and defendant lawyers. Lawyers representing the plaintiff typically receive a share of the value awarded the plaintiff, whereas defendant lawyers are typically on fixed wage contracts. Incentives to favor a connected lawyer are arguably heightened when the lawyer is known to receive parts of the value awarded.

The consequences of connected lawyers receiving a favorable treatment in court are potentially severe. If connected lawyers are favored by judges, this means that, to a certain extent, justice can be “bought.” Litigants who can afford to hire a connected lawyer are more likely to prevail in court and to get away with violating the law. In ongoing research, we investigate these downstream effects.

That family connections are central to judicial corruption in Brazil is strikingly illustrated by scandals spanning over two decades. We systematically collected all documented episodes of judicial corruption (*venda de sentenças*) in Brazil since 2003 through corruption-focused keyword searches across approximately 600 news articles from over 30 outlets, supplemented by book-length accounts of earlier operations (Vasconcelos, 2005; Alvim, 2011) (see Appendix B for details). We identified 16 independent operations investigated by the Federal Police or prosecutors. Of these, 13 (81%) involved relatives of judges in operational roles—as bribe collectors, money launderers, decision brokers, or financial conduits. Among the cases where the relatives’ professions could be determined, 92% involved relatives who were practicing lawyers. The legal profession provides professional cover for meetings and cash handling, a legitimate reason for receiving large payments disguised as legal fees (*honorários*), and plausible deniability. These scandals range from a sophisticated “cross-

scheme” (*esquema cruzado*) where children of different judges practiced law before each other’s parents to circumvent recusal rules (TJ-MS), to operations where each judge had a designated family member collecting bribes (TRT-1), to Brazil’s largest judicial corruption case in which sons of judges served as intermediaries, brokers, and money launderers (TJ-BA). The pattern predates our sample period: in the 2003 Operação Anaconda, a judge’s ex-wife managed the criminal organization’s finances, while in the 2007 Operação Hurricane, a desembargador’s son-in-law—himself the son of another desembargador at the same court—was arrested alongside him. As recently as 2023, Operação Habeas Pater targeted a TRF-1 desembargador and his son—a lawyer—for selling *habeas corpus* decisions to drug traffickers; the operation’s name itself references the father-son relationship. In only three of the 16 cases—all small-scale—was no family involvement documented. The phenomenon is not unique to Brazil. Ethnographic work on judicial corruption in Peru documents strikingly similar patterns: [Mujica \(2011\)](#) finds that bribes can only be offered through trusted personal networks, with family ties and university friendships serving as essential “capital,” and that judges engage in reciprocal exchanges (*trueque*) specifically designed to circumvent anti-nepotism laws—a mechanism that maps directly onto the Brazilian *esquema cruzado*. In India, the problem is sufficiently widespread that it has a name—the “Uncle Judge Syndrome,” in which lawyers related to judges routinely appear before their relatives’ courts. India’s Law Commission formally acknowledged the issue in its 230th Report ([Law Commission of India, 2009](#)), finding that 38% of Supreme Court judges had family connections to the judiciary or government, and recommending transfer policies to move judges away from courts where their relatives practice.⁴

The most closely related papers studying the consequences of judge-lawyer connections are Choi (2015), Conti and Valentini (2017), Liu and Zhang (2020), and [Liu et al. \(2025\)](#), who exploit the “revolving door” of former judges becoming lawyers in China to show that such lawyers deliver 8–23% higher win rates, driven by both “know how” and “know who.” None of these papers, however, deal with *family* connections between judges and lawyers—the channel that our scandal evidence identifies as central to judicial corruption.⁵ Other papers that look specifically at bias in labor courts are Cahuc et al that investigate

⁴The related problem of nepotistic *hiring* within the judiciary—judges appointing relatives to judicial positions—has been documented quantitatively in the Mexican federal judiciary by [Brassiolo et al. \(2021\)](#). While a distinct mechanism from the case-level favoritism we study, it reflects the same underlying penetration of family networks into judicial institutions. Even in the United States, where judicial corruption is rare, family members have served as intermediaries: in Operation Greylord, the FBI’s undercover investigation of Cook County courts in the 1980s, Judge Adam Stillo’s nephew (an attorney) acted as his “bagman” for bribes, and Judge Richard LeFevour’s cousin served the same role ([Hake and Klatt, 2015](#)). A recent ProPublica investigation found that dozens of federal judges presided over cases intersecting with their families’ financial interests without recusing ([ProPublica, 2024](#)).

⁵Fisman (2001) already noted how political connections were inter-wined with Suharto family ties.

”pro-labor” judge bias and its consequences for firm performance, Ichino et al (2002) and Marinescu (2011) which examine how local labor market conditions influence labor courts’ decisions, and Berger and Neugart (2011) who see how decisions vary depending on the government that appoint the labor judges. All these papers look at bias in other contexts than lawyer connections with the judge.

The results we report advance the existing literature in the following ways...

The next section presents institutional knowledge on the relevant aspects of the labor judiciary. Section 3 details the data on lawsuits, family relationships, lawyers, judges, and litigants. Section 4 presents our identification strategy and section 5 the results.

2 Institutions

Labor courts in Brazil are a branch of the judiciary at the federal level, specializing only in labor relations cases. The Superior Labor Court (*Tribunal Superior do Trabalho*) sits at the top, with twenty four appeals courts below (*Tribunal Regional do Trabalho*), defining the regional jurisdictions. Under each appeal court, there are several courts (*foro trabalhista*) that are divided into one or more court units (*vara trabalhista*).

Each court unit has one chief judge (*juiz titular de vara*) and a substitute judge (*juiz substituto*). Case are randomly distributed to court units. The only exception is new cases that are connected to a past case, for instance by involving the same litigants and being about the same issue. Such cases are distributed to the same court unit as the connected case (*dependência/prevenção*). Our data includes an indicator for whether the case was randomly assigned.

Another main institutional rule for our setup is that judge should be recused (*impedimento*) if the lawyer of any of the parts is up to a third-degree relative, which includes in-laws but not cousins. One of the parts should allege the recusal of the judge, who then rules on the request. If the judge recuses herself, she immediately sends the case to her substitute judge. If there is no substitute judge in the same court unit the case goes to the next court unit.⁶

The type of judicial cases we explore ...

3 Data

- Case data

⁶Articles 144 and 146 of the new *Código de Processo Civil* that entered into force in 2016, but already a National Justice Council (*Conselho Nacional de Justiça*) resolution since 2015.

- Family data
- Auxiliary data: education level and age of lawyers, firm size and sector (RAIS)

3.1 Descriptive Statistics

Among the top six ranked law firms in the area of civil and commercial litigation, 29 out of 455 partners and 126 out of 6,255 employees are relatives of judges. Partners in these top law firms are over twice as likely to be relatives of judges compared to partners in other law firms. Employees of these top law firms are five times more likely to be relatives of judges and eight times more likely to be children of judges than employees of other law firms.

4 Methods

To estimate the causal effect of a case being decided by a connected judge, we exploit that cases are randomly assigned judges. As our main estimation sample we select cases with a lawyer connected to at least one of the judges active in the court at the time the case is filed. Since cases are randomly assigned court units (varas), we consider only the main judges of each court unit. The judge deciding most cases in a court unit in the year the case is filed is considered the main judge (juiz titular) of the court unit. We consider two types of connections: (i) the lawyer being the relative of the judge, and (ii) the lawyer being a colleague of a relative of the judge. Two lawyers are considered colleagues if they appear in at least five cases together.

We take several steps to ensure that we only select cases that are indeed randomly assigned to courts. First, we exclude cases that are labeled as non-randomly distributed due to being connected to a past case. Second, we exclude court units that deviate more than 20% from the median court unit in the court in terms of received cases in the given year, indicating deviation from randomization. Finally, we exclude large courts (over 20 court units) where our randomization test fails.⁷

To estimate the causal effect of being assigned a connected judge, we use the following regression specification:

$$y_i = \alpha_{c(i),t(i)} + \beta \text{Connected}_i + \varepsilon_i \quad (1)$$

⁷In particular, in courts with many judges, cases assigned a connected judge tends to have a larger face value compared cases not assigned a connected judge. A possible reason is that in larger courts it is more common to change lawyers in response to the judge assignment, in particular for cases with a high face value.

where y_i is a measure of the outcome of court case i , Connected_i is an indicator for case i being assigned a connected judge, $\alpha_{c(i),t(i)}$ is a court by year of filing fixed effect, and ε_i is an error term. We control for court by filing year fixed effect since this is the level where we expect cases to be randomly assigned.

One complication arises from the fact that a given court case might be connected to more than one judge. Such court cases will mechanically have a higher likelihood of being assigned a connected judge than cases connected to only one judge. Thus, even when cases are randomly assigned to judges, a naive estimation of Equation (1) will lead to biased estimates if potential outcomes are correlated with the number of connected judges. To prevent such bias, we apply inverse probability weighting, a standard approach in observational studies to prevent bias due to differences in the probability of receiving treatment across observations.⁸. Our results are robust to imposing equal weighting and focusing on cases connected to only one judge.

5 Results

5.1 Summary statistics

Summary statistics for our main estimation sample—labor cases filed between 2014 and 2018 with a lawyer connected to an active judge in the court—is presented in Tables 1–3. In total, there are 205,560 such cases. In 16% of the cases, the connected lawyer represents the plaintiff (worker). In the remaining 84%, the connected lawyer represents the defendant (firm). The top two subjects are overtime work (38%) and prior notice of dismissal (28%). The majority of the cases ends in either a (partial) win for the plaintiff (38%) or a settlement (34%). The median time between filing and final decision is 214 days. Almost all the cases (97%) are decided within the time coverage of our data, alleviating concerns about right censoring. It is relatively common for labor judges to have a labor lawyer as a relative: 1,056 out of 3,231 judges in our data have at least one such relative. The most common lawyer relatives are spouses (417 judges), siblings (225 judges), children (137 judges), cousins (102 judges), siblings-in-law (100 judges), and nephews (79 judges). Many of these lawyers, however, have few or no cases in the court of their relative judge. Table 3 summarizes the number of cases involving relatives of judges *filed in the court of the judge*. Only 160 of the 417 lawyer spouses actually file a case in their spouse’s court. Among lawyers that argue

⁸In particular, we weigh each observation by the inverse probability of receiving the treatment it actually received. For instance, if case i is connected to two out of five judges in the court, we apply the weight 5/2 if the case is assigned a connected judge and the weight 5/3 otherwise. Inverse probability weighting creates a “pseudo-population” in which the probability of being treated equals 50% for all observations. See, e.g., [Hernán and Robins \(2010\)](#) for details.

cases in their spouse’s court, only three percent of their cases are filed there. For siblings, this number is slightly higher at eight percent. In total there are 8,971 cases filed in the court of the lawyer’s spouse, 4,912 cases filed in the court of the lawyer’s sibling, and 2,401 cases filed in the court of the lawyer’s parent. The number of cases involving other relatives are fewer. In the second panel of Table 3, we show the same statistics for *colleagues* of a judge’s relative.⁹ There are much more cases involving such weaker connections. For instance, there are 104,447 cases where the lawyer is the colleague of a sibling of an active judge in the court.

5.2 *Are Connected Lawyers More Successful?*

In Tables 4–5, we assess whether lawyers connected to judges are more successful than other judges. For this exercise, we construct a data set of all 152,848 lawyers appearing in at least one labor case, and run an OLS regression of measures of lawyer success on whether the lawyer is a relative of a judge or a colleague of a relative. We control for quadratic polynomials in the age and years of schooling of the lawyer, the gender of the lawyer, and municipality fixed effects. We estimate that lawyers that are relative of judges receive 75% more cases (0.564 log points) than other lawyers in the same municipality with the same age, gender, and level of schooling receive. Controlling for the number of cases received, relatives of judges have a 21% higher average face value of their cases than comparable lawyers have (0.195 log points), and represent firms that have 85% more employees (0.617 log points). Similarly, lawyers that are colleagues of judge’s relatives receive seven times as many cases.¹⁰ Controlling for the number of cases received, such lawyers have a 31 % higher average face value of their cases, and represent firms that have 13 times as many employees as firms represented by comparable lawyers. For completeness, we also show connected lawyers compare to other lawyers in average outcome of their cases in Table 5. Case outcomes, however, are harder to interpret as measures of “lawyer success” since connected lawyers and unconnected lawyers receive very different cases.

5.3 *The Causal Effect of Receiving a Connected Judge*

The fact that connected lawyers are more successful than other lawyers in the same municipality of the same age and level of education is not a proof of favoritism. Connected lawyers might have received a higher *quality* education or otherwise be more competent

⁹Two lawyers are considered colleagues if they appear in more than five cases together.

¹⁰The fact that colleagues of lawyers receive more cases, is, however, partly mechanical since lawyers who appear in many cases are more likely to appear in the same case as a relative of a judge in more than five cases.

or motivated than comparable lawyers in ways that are difficult to control for. To test whether connected lawyers owe parts of their success *to their connections*, we thus exploit that cases are randomly assigned judges. By comparing outcomes of cases randomly assigned a connected judge to the outcome of cases randomly assigned a judge not connected to the lawyer, we can estimate the extent lawyers receive a favorable treatment by their connected judge. It is important to notice, however, that this exercise will only produce a lower bound estimate of the favorable treatment received by connected lawyers, since such lawyers might also receive a favorable treatment when the case is assigned a judge they are not connected to.

Randomization Test

To test whether it is as good as random whether a case is assigned a connected judge, we assess whether cases assigned a connected judge differ from other cases along observable dimensions. In particular, we regress whether the case is assigned a connected judge on various pre-determined characteristics of the case using inverse propensity weighting and controlling for court by filing year fixed effects. The results are presented in Table 6. No case characteristics are statistically significant at the ten percent level, and the joint F test can not reject that cases assigned connected judges are equal to other cases along observable dimensions (p -value 0.56). Furthermore, the coefficients are small, implying that we can rule out large deviations from random assignment. For instance, the coefficient on "prior notice of dismissal" indicates that cases assigned a connected judge are only 0.1 percentage point less likely to be about this subject.¹¹ In Table 7, we test whether a case connected to a particular judge is more likely to be assigned this judge than other cases are. In particular, we construct a data set including all 2014–2018 labor cases with one observation per case per active judge in the court—in total 188 million observations. We then regress whether the case is assigned the indicated judge on whether a lawyer in the case is connected to that judge. We estimate that cases with relatives of judges are only 0.4 percentage points less likely than other cases are to be assigned to their relative's court unit. Similarly, cases where a litigant is represented by a colleague of a judge's relative are only 0.1 percentage point more likely to be assigned the connected judge than other cases are. None of the coefficients are statistically significant. We can thus not reject that it is random whether a case in our sample is assigned a connected judge.

¹¹Overall, 28% of all cases are about this subject.

Are Judges Recusing to Decide Cases Involving Connected Lawyers?

As discussed in Section 2, there are recusal rules aimed at preventing judges to decide cases with connected lawyers. In Table 8, we assess the extent these rules are followed in practice. In particular, we estimate Equation 1 with outcome variables whether the case is decided by the main judge in the court unit, a substitute judge in the court unit, or a judge in a different court unit. If recusal rules are followed, we would expect that the probability of the main judge deciding the case drops to zero when the case is assigned the connected judge’s court unit.

In the first two rows, we see that the probability of the case being decided by the main judge drops by 41 and 42 percentage points when the case is assigned the connected judge for lawyers that are, respectively, close relatives and extended relatives covered by the recusal rules. We see no such effect for cousins, who are not covered by the recusal rules. Since the baseline probability of being decided by the main judge is 45%, this means that practically no cases are decided by the relative of the lawyer: judges to recuse themselves in cases with relative lawyers. Does that mean that we should not expect lawyers to receive a favorable treatment when their cases are assigned their relative judge? Not necessarily. About half of the drop in decisions by the main judge is accounted for by an increase in the number of cases decided by a substitute judge in the same court unit. To the extent that the substitute and the main judge in the court unit collaborate closely, the substitute judge might treat relatives of the main judge favorably.

For cases involving colleagues of relatives of the judge, however, the judge only recuses herself in about half of the cases: The drop in the share of cases decided by the main judge is only 29 and 16 percentage points when assigned the court unit of the connected judge for cases filed before 2015 and after 2015, respectively. Interestingly, judges do not recuse themselves more in these cases after 2015, when the recusal rules governing such cases became stricter. We can not ascertain, however, whether the recusal rules are actually violated: The judge is only required to recuse herself if the lawyer works for the same law firm as the relative. Two lawyers might work on the same cases without formally being part of the same law firm. The fact that the judge does not recuse herself in the majority of cases where the lawyer is a colleague of a relative, however, opens up for favoritism.

Main results

In Table 9, we present our main results—the causal effect of a case being assigned a judge connected to a lawyer. Since the effect of a case being assigned a judge connected to a lawyer might go in opposing directions depending on whether the lawyer represents the plaintiff or

the defendant, we run separate regressions for connections involving plaintiff lawyers (Panel A) and defendant lawyers (Panel B).¹² In the first row of Panel A, we consider cases with plaintiff lawyers who are relatives of an active judge in the court. Even though these cases are decided by the substitute judge when they are assigned the connected judge—due to recusal rules—we see clear signs of favoritism: If the case is assigned to the relative’s court unit, we see an increase of 46% (0.38 log points) in the value awarded the plaintiff, a 5 percentage point higher likelihood of a decision in favor of the plaintiff, and a reduction of 19% (0.215 log points) in the duration between filing and final decision.¹³ The coefficients are significant at the ten, five, and one percent levels, respectively. In the second row, we consider colleagues of judge’s relatives, and find a similar pattern: If a case with a plaintiff lawyer who is a colleague of a judge’s relative is assigned the connected judge, the value awarded increases by 30% and the case duration decreases by 18% compared to if the case is assigned another judge. We unpack this result in the remaining rows of Panel A, and find that the result is stronger for colleagues of close relatives than for colleagues of extended family and for colleagues with over 20 joint cases with the relative. The difference in effects between colleagues above and below 20 joint cases with a relative is, however, not statistically significant.

In Panel B, we consider defendant lawyers connected to judges. Interestingly, even though the number of observations increases four-fold, we find almost no statistically significant effects of being assigned the connected judge for defendant lawyers. The only exception is that cases where a relative of the judge represents a defendant last 19% longer when they are assigned the connected judge. This result could be a sign of favoritism: The judge might seek to purposefully delay the decision by sitting on the case instead of immediately recusing herself, favoring the defendant. But the result could also be just due to the extra time it takes to comply with the recusal rules. The absence of favoritism for defendant lawyers is puzzling. One explanation, however, could lie in the different types of contracts under which plaintiff and defendant lawyers operate: Plaintiff lawyers typically receive a share of the value awarded as compensation whereas defendant lawyers are typically on fixed wage contracts that do not depend on the outcome of the case. Incentives to favor connected lawyers are thus arguably higher if the lawyer represents the plaintiff.

¹²Alternatively, we could have run a single regression on the effect of being assigned a judge connected to a plaintiff lawyer and a defendant lawyer as separate explanatory variables. Since there are very few cases where lawyers from both sides are connected to a judge, such a model is almost equivalent to running separate regressions.

¹³The value awarded equals the settlement value for settled cases.

Appeal Outcomes

In Table 10, we look at appeal outcomes. Interestingly, cases with a connected plaintiff lawyer are not more likely to be appealed by the defendant when they are assigned a connected judge. One explanation could be that the defendant’s appeal strategy does not depend highly on the value awarded. We do estimate that the defendant is more likely to win on appeal when the case is assigned a judge connected to the plaintiff lawyer, suggesting a lower quality decision when the case is decided by a connected judge. This effect, however, is not statistically significant. Being assigned a judge connected to a plaintiff lawyer, however, significantly reduces plaintiff appeals (3.8 percentage points reduction) and the share of cases where the plaintiff wins on appeal (2.7 percentage points reduction). The latter is a large effect compared to the 12% baseline probability of winning on appeal, and means that the plaintiff is also less likely to win on appeal *conditional on appealing*.

Heterogeneous Effects

In Table 11, we show heterogeneous effects of our main results based on the number of judges in the court and the face value of the case. We are not able to detect any differences in effects between large and small courts and high and low value cases, respectively.

5.4 Mechanisms: Why Are Connected Lawyers Favored?

Why do judges favor connected lawyer? A possible explanation is that lawyers better know how to argue a case in front of judges they know. In other words, lawyers are better at convincing connected judges. While we can not rule out that this is part of the explanation of our results, this mechanism can not explain the fact that judges also give faster attendance to connected plaintiff lawyers. In Table 12, we show that this effect is driven by a shorter time until the first hearing: The duration between filing and the first hearing reduces by 13% when the case is assigned the connected judge. Thus judges favor connected plaintiff lawyers even before hearing their arguments. We can thus conclude that the favored treatment received by connected lawyers is not just coming from lawyers being better at convincing judges they know, and that favoritism is likely part of the explanation.

6 Conclusion

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Online Appendix to “Judicial Connections”

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A Appendix to Section 3

B Family Involvement in Judicial Corruption Scandals

To document the role of family connections in judicial corruption, we systematically collected news articles on judicial corruption episodes in Brazil. Our collection comprises approximately 600 articles from over 30 outlets, including Folha de S. Paulo, O Globo, Piauí, Estadão, Conjur, Migalhas, JOTA, and regional newspapers. We supplemented this with book-length accounts of earlier operations (Vasconcelos, 2005; Alvim, 2011) and cross-checked our episode list for completeness using seven targeted web searches (e.g., “operação venda de sentenças juiz desembargador Brasil,” “corrupção judicial juiz preso afastado,” “CNJ aposentadoria compulsória corrupção”), examining the first page of results for each query. This cross-check confirmed that no additional organized operations exist beyond those already in our catalog. We also reviewed a systematic analysis of CNJ disciplinary records by The Intercept Brasil, which identified 21 individual *venda de sentenças* cases since 2005—a different unit of analysis from our organized operations, but which reinforces our finding: even among these smaller individual cases, family members appear as intermediaries (a son delivering bribe payments in TJ-BA, a son participating in a liminar-selling scheme in RN, a sister’s bank account used to transfer bribe money in Pará). We note that CNJ disciplinary records document 135 cases of judicial punishment since 2007, but these cover all forms of misconduct (not just corruption), are not publicly available in disaggregated form, and many *venda de sentenças* cases bypass the CNJ entirely through criminal prosecution at the STJ. Our unit of analysis is organized corruption *operations*—multi-person schemes investigated by the Federal Police or prosecutors—rather than individual disciplinary proceedings. Crucially, we identified corruption episodes through *corruption-focused* search queries (e.g., “venda de sentenças,” “corrupção judiciário,” and names of specific police operations) rather than searches for family connections, avoiding selection on the outcome of interest.¹

Table B.1 lists all 16 independent judicial corruption operations we identified through corruption-focused searches, spanning 1998–2024 across twelve different courts. For each episode, we document whether relatives of judges were involved, who these relatives were, whether they were lawyers, and what role they played in the scheme.

Of the 16 operations, 13 (81%) involved relatives of judges in operational roles. Among the twelve cases where the relatives’ professions could be determined, eleven (92%) involved relatives who were practicing lawyers or judges. The three cases without documented family

¹We also collected articles through family-focused queries (“filhotismo,” “parente advogado ministro,” etc.), which identified additional episodes involving family connections at the STF and TST. These are excluded from the main count to avoid selection bias. The complete search log documenting all queries, outlets, and page depths is available in the project repository.

involvement are all small-scale: a single judge retired for selling sentences (TJ-RJ), a federal precatório fraud, and the famous “Lalau” embezzlement at the TRT-2 (where the judge’s ex-son-in-law reported him, but family did not enable the scheme).

The roles played by family members fall into several categories: (i) *bribe collection and delivery*, where relatives physically received cash from intermediaries and delivered it to judges; (ii) *money laundering*, through shell companies, simulated transactions, or asset purchases in relatives’ names; (iii) *financial conduit*, where law firms received payments disguised as legal fees (*honorários*); (iv) *decision brokering*, where relatives negotiated the sale of judicial decisions on behalf of their parents; and (v) *cross-family cooperation*, where children of different judges collaborated as mutual brokers, circumventing recusal rules.

The legal profession plays a central enabling role. Being a lawyer provides: professional cover for meetings with other lawyers and handling money; a legitimate reason to receive large payments (legal fees); access to court buildings and processes; and plausible deniability—payments can be framed as fees for legal services. The most sophisticated form of this exploitation appears in the TJ-MS “esquema cruzado,” where judges’ children did not practice before their own parent (which would trigger *impedimento*) but before each other’s parents, explicitly adapting to circumvent recusal rules while maintaining reciprocal benefit.

Table B.1: Family involvement in judicial corruption operations in Brazil (1998–2024). Episodes identified through corruption-focused news searches across ~600 articles from 30+ outlets, supplemented by book-length accounts.

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Relatives	Lawyers?	Role of relatives
Op. Anaconda	TRF-3	2003	Yes	Norma	Mixed:	Ex-wife was “administradora dos
				Cunha (ex-wife),	ex-wife	ganhos da organização”; R\$550K
				Vera Cecília (sister,	man-	cash found at her apartment. In-
				ex-auditor), Vera	aged	structed destruction of documents
				Cristina (niece, PF	cash;	before raid. Sister was ex-Receita
				delegate), Casem	broth-	Federal auditor; niece was PF del-
				+ Ali Mazloun	ers	egate suspected of aiding scheme.
				(brothers, both	were	Mazloun brothers both judges at
				judges)	judges;	same court. Source: Vasconcelos
					niece	(2005).
Op. Hurricane	TRF-2	2007	Yes		was	
					PF	
					dele-	
					gate	
				Silvério	Yes	Son-in-law arrested with desembar-
				Júnior (son-in-law,	(lawyer)	gador; was son of another desembar-
				son of desembar-		gador at same court. A procurador
				gador at same court)		noted operation could have targeted
						other judges “que tinham filhos,
						genros, mulheres e outros parentes
						advogados.” Source: Alvim (2011) .

Table B.1: (continued)

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Rélatives	Lawyers?	Role of relatives
Op. Faroeste	TJ-BA	2019	Yes	Vasco (son), Karla Janaína (niece), Márcio Miranda (son-in-law), Arthur Barata (son), Rui Barata (son), Ivanilton Jr. (son)	Rusciolelli All lawyers	Bribe collection and delivery: sons received cash from intermediary lawyers and delivered to parents. Money laundering: niece created fake association to channel funds. Cross-family brokering: sons of different judges collaborated. Obstruction: family destroyed evidence.
Op. Última Ra-tio	TJ-MS	2024	Yes	Rodrigo (son), Renata Pimentel (daughter), Marcus Abreu (son), Ana Carolina Abreu (daughter), Diogo Rodrigues (son), Camila Bastos (daughter), Divoncir Jr. (son), Fábio Leandro (son)	All lawyers	<i>Esquema cruzado</i> : children practiced law before each other's parents, circumventing recusal rules. Financial conduit: law firms received payments as fees; ~1,000 fractionated deposits. Simulated cattle invoices to transfer money between families.

Table B.1: (continued)

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Rélatives	Thadeu	Mostly	Lawyers? Role of relatives
Op. Sisamnes	STJ	2024	Yes	Mauro (son), Anna Noronha (daughter), Catarina Buzzi (daughter), Karine Nunes Marques (sister), Maria Carolina Tarelho (stepdaughter), Aline Gonçalves (wife)	Thadeu Noronha (daughter), Catarina Buzzi (daughter), Karine Nunes Marques (sister), Maria Carolina Tarelho (stepdaughter), Aline Gonçalves (wife)	Mostly	Son inserted into R\$12M contract as payment for father's ruling. Daughters received R\$300K–1.1M from scheme-linked funds. Catarina Buzzi notably did not have OAB card. Wife received R\$938K via shell company.
Op. Mais Valia	TRT-1	2021	Yes	Eduarda P. da Cruz (sister), Sônia R. Martins (wife), Marcello Zorzenon (son), Leila Cavalcante (wife)	Eduarda P. da Cruz (sister), Sônia R. Martins (wife), Marcello Zorzenon (son), Leila Cavalcante (wife)	Eduarda P. da Cruz (sister), Sônia R. Martins (wife), Marcello Zorzenon (son), Leila Cavalcante (wife)	Designated collectors: each of 4 judges had one specific family member collecting bribes. Companies pressured to retain sister's law firm. Bribes disguised as legal fees. Sister transferred R\$3.6M to brother.

Table B.1: (continued)

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Rélatives	Lawyers?	Role of relatives
Op. 18 Minutos	TJ-MA	2024	Yes	Nelma Sarney Costa (sister-in-law of ex-president Sarney), Edilázio Jr. (son-in-law)	Nelma is judge; Edilázio is politician	Political-family nexus: bargadora is sister-in-law of ex-president Sarney; son-in-law (ex-deputy) involved in manipulating case distribution. R\$50M estimated diverted.
Op. Naufrágio	TJ-ES	2008	Yes	Paulo Guerra Duque (son), Frederico Schaider Pimentel (son of court president)	Frederico was former judge; Paulo was in-term-diary	Sons brokered favorable decisions for clients (convicted: 21 and 16.5 year sentences). Son of court president manipulated case distribution. 17 of 24 TJ-ES judges had first-degree relatives at court.
Op. Churras-cada	TJ-GO	2024	Yes	Marcus Chaves (son of ex-president)	Aprígio Yes	Son brokered judicial promotions and favorable decisions. After favorable sentence, son's firm received R\$500K immediately.

Table B.1: (continued)

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Rélatives	Lawyers?	Role of relatives
Venda sentenças SP	TJ-SP	2024	Yes	Ivo de Almeida Jr. (son)	No (real estate)	Son created real estate company to hide bribe proceeds. R\$641K deposited to son's company. Told police deposits were from "selling wines."
Venda sentenças TO	TJ-TO	2020	Yes	Family of ex-president (limited detail)	Unknown	Described as "esquema familiar" of ex-president. Suspects complained about installment bribes (<i>propina parcelada</i>).
Venda sentenças MT	TJ-MT	2024	Yes	Mauro Thadeu de Moraes (son); Op. Asafe (2010); Célia Cury (wife), Cláudio Jr. (son-in-law), Rodrigo Vieira (son-in-law)	All lawyers	Son placed into R\$12M legal services contract as payment for father's decision. Predecessor scandal (2010): wife and sons-in-law practiced law while father judged.
Op. Habeas Pa-ter	TRF-1	2023	Yes	Ravik Bello Ribeiro (son of des. Cândido Ribeiro)	Yes (lawyer)	Father (ex-president of TRF-1) and son suspected of selling <i>habeas corpus</i> decisions to drug traffickers. R\$270K cash found at son's home. Operation name references father-son relationship.

Table B.1: (continued)

Episode	Court	Year	Family	Rélatives	Lawyers?	Role of relatives
Judge “Lalau”	TRT-2	1998	No	— (reported by ex-son-in-law)	—	Presidente do TRT-SP diverted R\$169.5M from labor court forum construction. Convicted to 26 years. Most famous judicial corruption case in Brazil. Embezzlement, not <i>venda de sentenças</i> . Family reported, not enabled.
Venda sentenças RJ	TJ-RJ	2021	No	—	—	Solo operation: judge retired for selling sentences and illegal charges.
Fraude catórios	pre-TRF	2020	No	—	—	Federal judge and lawyers arrested for precatório fraud.